

Challenges of International Communication

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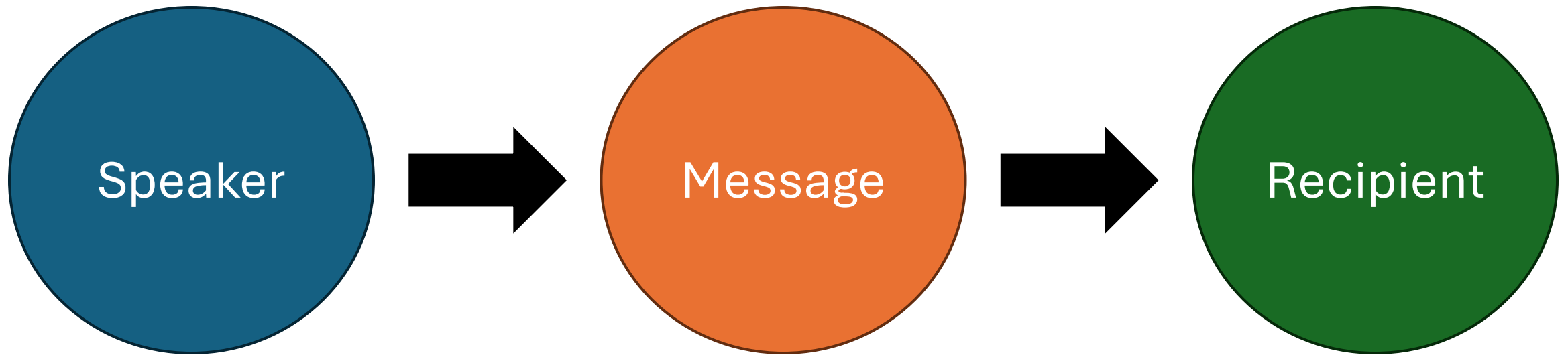
An example:

- Which conjunction fits in the following sentence?
- We are dancing ____ it is raining.

An example:

- We are dancing ____ it is raining.
- although / though / even though: we don't care about the rain
- because: we are happy about the rain
- while / when: we are only dancing during the rain
- so / until: our dancing let it rain

Basic communication model



High- and Low-Context Culture

High-Context	Low-Context
High awareness of politeness, gestures, non-verbal, indirect communication	Low awareness of these aspects, direct communication
Focus on the group, importance of relationships, shared values and tradition	Focus on the individual
Japan, China, Korea, the Global South, Russia, East and Southern Europe, Indigenous People, ethnic minorities (e.g., Black Americans in the U.S.)	Western and Northern Europe, the U.S.

Moreover ...

- People are highly diverse and unique, for example:
 - Social class (e.g., poor or rich)
 - Education (e.g., high school or university)
 - Profession (e.g., farmer or manager)
 - Sexual minority (e.g., non-binary or LGBTQ)
 - Health condition (e.g., disease or disability)
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- All these factors can also influence one's communication

AI and digital communication

- AI can help us to translate and communicate very easily
- But AI has its limits, for example:
- AI barely understands context and background (if not included into the prompts)
- Nuances and double meaning might get lost
- Japanese levels of politeness and English plain language
- Japanese does often not mention subject or gender, which can lead to misunderstanding

An example:

- The first sentence of Kawabata Yasunari's novel *Snow Country*
- 「国境の長いトンネルを抜けると雪国であった。」
- Options for the translation:
 - “The train came out of the long tunnel into the snow country.”
 - “As one came out of the long tunnel at the border, it was the snow country.”
 - “As the long tunnel at the border ended, the snow country appeared.”
 - “Coming out of the long tunnel that marked the border, there was snow country.”
 - “Upon exiting the long tunnel at the national border, one found oneself in the snow country.”

Recommendations for international communication

- Use simple language (at least at the beginning)
- Speak/write clearly and not too fast
- Explain difficult words or describe them with other words
- Be respectful and acknowledge diverse differences
- (Maybe use AI to check if your language is clear)
- Don't worry about misunderstandings: they can always happen!

Group Discussion

- Do you have experience with international communication?
 - Which challenges did you face?
 - How could you solve them?
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- Summarize the results of your group and be able to present them briefly to the other students!